a new multilateral free-trade agreement, the Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP), the Pentagon announced increased troop deployments to the Asia-Pacific and the shifting of US Navy assets to the region to account for fully 60 percent of all US naval strength.[6]

In response, Beijing claimed the entire South China Sea as its territorial waters and a "core national interest."[7] Reports and eventually video trickled out of People's Liberation Army (PLA) Navy ships harassing US Navy ships operating in the South China Sea on various occasions, raising memories of the March 2001 collision between a US Navy surveillance plane and a Chinese fighter jet, caused by the reckless flying on the part of the Chinese pilot, who died in the incident.[8]

When Washington failed to support Manila during the Scarborough Shoal crisis of mid-2012, allowing China to take effective control of the shoal, Beijing felt assured that US commitments to support allies in the South China Sea were hollow. New Chinese leader Xi Jinping added more concrete action to rhetoric, staging seemingly uncoordinated encounters once he came to power in late 2012. Starting around 2013, despite the Obama administration's continuing high-level bilateral meetings, the PRC began a major land-reclamation campaign in the Spratlys and then proceeded to militarize its new possessions, as well as some older ones in the Paracels.[9] The Chinese military built three Pearl Harbor–size port facilities, laid runways capable of handling fighter jets and bombers, installed radar and antiship and antiaircraft weapons, and built barracks and storage facilities, among other actions. The emplacement of airfields and weaponry on its claimed possessions gave Beijing the ability to effectively control the heart of the South China Sea, through which as much as 70 percent of global trade passed, and to project power throughout the region. It also launched its first aircraft carrier and conducted military exercises hundreds of miles from its recognized territorial waters, near the strategic waterways of Southeast Asian nations. PLA Navy (PLAN) ships regularly transited into the Indian Ocean and through strategic straits near Japan into the western Pacific Ocean.